

Authority Without Attribution

An Operational Reflection on Trust and Accountability

One of the most dangerous conditions in any system is authority without attribution.

Most people think authority is the ability to make decisions.

That is only part of the story.

Authority is also the ability to create consequences.

To allocate resources.

To establish priorities.

To shape behavior.

To influence outcomes.

The more authority an individual possesses, the greater their impact on the system.

This creates an important requirement.

Impact should be attributable.

If decisions create consequences, those consequences should remain connected to the decisions that created them.

When this connection exists, systems can learn.

Success can be repeated.

Failure can be corrected.

Accountability becomes possible.

When the connection disappears, something else emerges.

Authority without attribution.

The condition is surprisingly common.

A committee makes a decision.

Nobody owns the outcome.

A requirement is imposed.

Nobody remembers who imposed it.

A policy is established.

Nobody accepts responsibility for its consequences.

A project changes direction.

Nobody can identify who made the decision.

The authority existed.

The attribution did not.

This creates problems immediately.

Good decisions become difficult to recognize.

Poor decisions become difficult to correct.

Lessons become difficult to learn.

The system loses visibility into cause and effect.

The outcome remains.

The ownership disappears.

Organizations often experience this as frustration.

People encounter constraints that nobody can explain.

Requirements that nobody can justify.

Processes that nobody can modify.

The system continues operating.

The rationale becomes lost.

Over time, authority becomes distributed throughout the organization while attribution gradually evaporates.

This creates a peculiar phenomenon.

The organization becomes filled with decisions that have no identifiable decision-maker.

Everyone is affected.

Nobody is responsible.

The consequences can be significant.

Without attribution, feedback weakens.

Without feedback, learning weakens.

Without learning, adaptation weakens.

The system becomes increasingly difficult to improve.

This is one reason mature organizations often struggle with legacy processes.

The original problem may have disappeared years ago.

The original decision-makers may have retired.

The process remains.

The authority that created it is gone.

The consequences continue.

The attribution vanished long ago.

Technology systems experience similar challenges.

Permissions are granted.

Exceptions are approved.

Configurations are changed.

Years later nobody knows why.

The access remains.

The rule remains.

The exception remains.

The decision survives longer than the knowledge that created it.

The organization inherits consequences without inheriting understanding.

The same pattern appears in governments.

Corporations.

Military organizations.

Communities.

Even families.

Rules persist.

Norms persist.

Expectations persist.

The reasons often disappear.

This is why effective systems place enormous value on traceability.

Not because documentation is inherently valuable.

Because attribution enables learning.

The ability to answer:

- “Who made this decision?”
- “Why was it made?”
- “What assumptions existed at the time?”
- “What outcome was expected?”

These questions transform history from mystery into information.

Authority without attribution prevents this.

The system loses its memory.

The consequences remain visible.

The causes become invisible.

The most effective leaders understand that authority and attribution must remain connected.

Not to assign blame.

To preserve learning.

Blame focuses on punishment.

Attribution focuses on understanding.

The distinction matters.

Authority creates outcomes.

Attribution creates understanding.

The strongest systems preserve both.

Organizations that preserve attribution adapt more effectively.

Organizations that lose attribution accumulate mystery.

The larger the organization becomes, the more important this principle becomes.

Complex systems already struggle to understand themselves.

Removing attribution makes the challenge significantly worse.

Authority should not operate anonymously.

Influence should not operate invisibly.

Decisions should not become detached from their origins.

Not because people need someone to blame.

Because systems need a way to learn.

The weakest systems eventually lose one of them.

And when authority survives without attribution, consequences often survive longer than the reasons that created them.

Tommy Burke is a cybersecurity engineer, systems thinker, author, and retired U.S. Army veteran exploring complexity, trust, authority, and the behavior of human, organizational, and technical systems.

“Asymmetric Precision”